

Crested Gecko (*Correlophus Ciliatus*)

Difficulty: Easy

Crested geckos are medium-sized (6-8" long) lizards that range in color and pattern depending on what morph they may be. They have wide sticky toe pads with small nails that give them the ability to climb up smooth surfaces, and a crest that typically runs from above their eyes down their back.

Crested geckos are native to New Caledonia, a group of islands between Fiji and Australia. Crested geckos have a 15-20 year lifespan when cared for properly, and may live longer in some cases.

Shopping List

- Front-opening 18" x 18" x 24" glass terrarium
- 10w-25w Ceramic heater (Depending on ambient temperature)
- 5.5" dome lamp with ceramic socket
- Plug-in light timer
- Infrared thermometer
- Pressure sprayer
- Reptisafe or similar water conditioner
- Digital thermometer/hygrometer
- 2-4" organic soil or similar substrate
- Decor (Vines, coconut hides, foliage, etc.)
- Feeding ledge W/ Cups
- Small feeding cups
- Feeding tongs
- Crested gecko diet powder
- Calcium supplement W/ D3

Housing

Although crested geckos are small, they still need an enclosure that is large enough to give them adequate opportunity to explore, hunt, and generally exercise natural behaviors. They are also arboreal, which means that they are a tree-dwelling species, and prefer terrariums that are taller than they are wide. A strongly recommended size for an adult crested is an 18"x18"x24" terrarium and if possible, larger is always better for any captive pet.

Young crested geckos (less than 12g) benefit from being kept in a smaller, temporary "growout" enclosure (around 5 gallons, or roughly 12" x 12" x 12") until they are large enough to safely navigate a full-sized adult enclosure.

Lighting & UVB

Crested geckos are crepuscular, which means that they are active at night, but mostly around sunset. This means that they are likely to prefer relatively cooler temperatures and lower levels of UVB. If a keeper feels inclined to provide UVB, they should only use an Arcadia Shade Dweller bulb or a Reptisun 5.0 when used above a mesh lid. Do not provide calcium powder with D3, as too much UVB and D3 supplement can cause poisoning in some reptiles.

Heating

Crested geckos are cold-blooded, which means that they have to move between areas of different temperatures in order to regulate their body temperature. In the wild, crested geckos warm up during the day by sleeping in a warm patch of sunlight. In captivity, sunlight can be replicated with a heat lamp.

Basking area temperature: 82-85°F (28-29°C)

Cool zone temperature: 70-75°F (21-24°C)

Nighttime temperature: 65-72°F (18-22°C)

The basking area should be a vine, branch, or cluster of foliage directly under the heat lamp. Because your crested gecko is arboreal and will be living in a tall enclosure, the warmest temperatures will be at the top (near the heat lamp), and the coolest temperatures will be toward the bottom. You will need vines, branches, and foliage at all levels to allow for proper thermoregulation. The use of a digital thermometer/hygrometer is strongly recommended.

Humidity

Crested geckos do best in a high-humidity environment, with an average humidity of 60-80%. Humidity levels that are consistently too high or low can cause health problems for your gecko. To raise the humidity in your crested gecko's enclosure (and provide an extra source of drinking water), use a sprayer to wet down the enclosure every morning and evening as needed.

It's best to use tap water that's been treated with water conditioner for misting, rather than distilled or reverse-osmosis water. Tap water contains essential minerals that are important to your gecko's health, and distilled water may actually suck those minerals out of your gecko.

Substrate

Because crested geckos are arboreal (tree-dwelling), they don't spend much time on the ground. The substrate is primarily used to catch feces and waste, as well as cushion the gecko in the event of a fall. An easy DIY substrate is a mix of 40% organic top soil, 40% coco coir fiber and 20% untreated sphagnum moss. As a bonus, add a generous layer of cleaned leaf litter on top.

Feces and urates should be removed daily, and contaminated substrate should be scooped out and replaced. The substrate should be completely replaced once every 1-3 months, depending on your needs.

Food

Crested geckos are omnivores, which means that they need a balanced diet of both plant and insect-based foods to get the nutrition that they need. As pets, it's best to feed them a specially-formulated, high-quality crested gecko diet plus live insects. Crested gecko diet (CGD) is a nutritionally-complete powder that becomes a meal replacement smoothie when water is added.

Typically any store bought CGD will be sufficient for your crested gecko. Crickets and dubia roaches will be the primary feeder insect for your gecko, with mealworms and small hornworms being an occasional treat.

How often crested geckos need to eat depends on age:

Hatchlings and Juveniles (0-12 months) — CGD daily, insects 1-2x/week

Adults (>12 months) — CGD every 2-3 days, insects 1x/week

Supplements

Crested gecko diet is already fortified and balanced with a variety of vitamins and minerals. However, feeder insects need to be "dusted" with a light coating of calcium powder to balance the calcium- phosphorus ratio. The biggest thing to remember with supplements is:

If using UVB over the enclosure: Do not use a supplement that has D3 (Unless used rarely)

If not using UVB: It is safe to use any supplement with D3

Any store bought calcium powder will be sufficient for healthy growth of a crested gecko.

Decor

Decorations play a vital role in your crested gecko's enclosure as environmental enrichment. Enrichment items encourage exercise, stimulate your pet's natural instincts, and help promote overall wellbeing. Good decor can include but is not limited to: Hanging coconut hides, vines, branches, bamboo shoots, artificial leaves, small log hides, etc.

Cohabitation

Can multiple crested geckos be housed in the same enclosure?

Although there are instances of multiple females or even one male and several females being successfully kept together, this requires a larger enclosure and particularly careful husbandry. If the geckos don't get along, they can fight and severely injure one another. This is why cohabitation is not recommended for novice keepers.

Males should never be housed together!